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Nupe religion

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5. SOLEMNIZATIONS AND SOCIAL STRUCTURE

There is no need to point to the close affinity of the ceremonials surrounding birth, marriage, and death, with the rituals of more general religious bearing. Both operate with the same elements—private (or esoteric) invocations, libations, communal meals, and public ‘merry-making’ in the concluding phase. Both, too, conspicuously involve numerical calculations defining the occasion and sequence of rites. The congregations, of course, differ, though there is some overlap; for certain *kuti*, like the solemnizations, mobilize the kin group only, while at the funerary rites of men of standing all the dignitaries of the community will be represented. Like the *kuti*, finally, the ceremonials surrounding the crises of life have their implicit as well as their professed aims. The latter could not be ‘professed’ more clearly. The *suna* is there to name the infant in solemn fashion, and hence to assign to it its future place in the society while at the same time invoking divine protection; the wedding ceremonial sanctifies the union of man and wife and holds out the promise of progeny; and the funeral ceremonial disposes of the dead while one prays that there may be no further deaths; it imposes mourning as well as cancels it, and thus repeats or dramatizes, in the ritual sequence, the endless cycle of human existence. We have, I think rightly, called these rituals solemnizations; for they hallow all these events through relating them with the supernatural. But they do more. Through the form they take, that is, through the manner in which the rituals mobilize their particular congregations, they also express the principles and values governing the structure of the society. Think of the rules assigned to the father and grandfather in the ceremonial of birth, the former being expected to collect the ‘medicines’ needed for an easy confinement and to consult the diviner, the latter to announce the new-born’s name. Or think of the complicated exchange of gifts which concludes the marriage ceremonial, of the double sacrifice in the bride’s and the bridegroom’s house, and of the

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selection of the bridegroom's envoys and the bride's companions. The funerary rites throw into relief both the social distinctions that go with sex, ¹³¹ age, and status and the varying degrees of kinship; even so specific a feature as joking relationship is built into the ceremonial.

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